car to return to the Pentagon on that beautiful fall evening, I feared I might never live to see another Saturday night.'[43]

If this was the closest we have been to Armageddon, then it is no exaggeration to say that Saturday, 27 October 1962 was the most important day in human history. That history is not confined to what happened in the Kremlin and the White House. Events at sea, in the air, and on land, and decisions taken by subordinate military officials, now form an integral part of missile crisis narratives and have generated considerable evidence of the risk of 'inadvertent nuclear war' in October (and November) 1962. They are discussed in detail in chapter seven, where the risk of nuclear war is explored in more systematic fashion.

Khrushchev's letter of Saturday, 27 October was broadcast on Radio Moscow. Little thought seems to have been given to the potential hazards of public diplomacy. The letter was formal in language and, most importantly, included the demand that any deal should include withdrawal of 'analogous weapons' from Turkey:

> We agree to remove those weapons from Cuba which you regard as offensive weapons. We agree to do this and to state this commitment in the United Nations. Your representatives will make a statement to the effect that the United States, on its part, bearing in mind the anxiety and concern of the Soviet state, will evacuate its analogous weapons from Turkey. Let us reach an understanding on what time you and we need to put this into effect.
>
> After this, representatives of the U.N. Security Council could control on-the-spot fulfillment of these commitments. Of course, it is necessary that the Governments of Cuba and Turkey would allow these representatives to come to their countries and check fulfillment of this commitment, which each side undertakes.[44]

ExComm was still debating how to respond to Khrushchev's messages when news came through that a U-2 had been shot down over Cuba and its pilot killed.